

MONTAFONCHEESEFACTORYEDIT

This week we're broadcasting from Austria, and we're at a very special place in the Montefon region of Austria, the Kaiserhaus. Is that how I say it? I'm with Werner Fritz, who is the manager and owner here. Kaiserhaus? Yeah, if you say it in German, you say Kaiserhaus, and in English, cheese house.

Very simple. Yeah, a house for the cheese. The cheese here is absolutely magnificent.

Now, I just had the speciality of the house, where you get a little fondue-type arrangement with the candles, and you melt the cheese. It's a very funny thing. You can make it with candles.

Then you've got the right feeling. It's handlebar. You can take it with you to ski, or in the mountains if you walk, or in the cinema, or wherever you want, for the first candlelight dinner.

Katrin was explaining to me that there's three levels of where the cattle and the dairy cows are for different times of the year here in the region. Can you tell us a bit about that? It's very special in Vorarlberg. We call it three-step farming.

The first time, the cows are in the villages, and you can say this is from October to April, often maybe May. The first step, they are in the village. Afterwards, in May, they go to the mazes.

You have to know this is something like a little farm up about 1,000 meters high. That's the first step for the cows to come from the village up to the mountain. It's a relaxing place for them, for the clima, for the high position.

If they have been down in the village over the winter, then they often got no condition, and they have to make a little bit of training, the first step. Afterwards, if the weather is fine, they start in June. It depends on the weather, really.

We got often snow also in June. In the first June, they go up to the Alps. These Alps are often about 1,500 meters high.

They go up to about 3,500 meters. These are the three steps. If the weather is also okay, everything depends on the weather, they got about 90 days on the Alps.

Often in September, the first week or the second week, they come down to the village, and then they stay in the village. We say the cows, they make vacation in summertime. It's a very special time also for the farmers.

They got a lot of time to do everything they have to do in the villages. Tell us about the specialty cheeses you have here at the Cheese House in Montaufon. We'll give the address later so people can find you online.

There must be some really special things that you like that you can tell us about. This area, Montaufon, is a special place for one cheese. This cheese is called Sour Cheese.

You can say it in English. This Sour Cheese is a very, very old cheese. There is a text document from the 12th century, and they paid taxes in Switzerland for the church.

It's one of the oldest documented cheeses all over the world. This cheese, every old cheese got a special story. The story of this cheese is they make it without fat.

The first time, they take the milk, then they take the fat away. Easy way, you have to take the milk for about eight hours, then you got the fat on the top, and you can put the fat away. With this fat, they make milk, milk butter.

If you get a fresh butter with no chemical inside, this butter will be quality takes about four to five days. Afterwards, you got the second chance to keep the fat in your business. You heat it up once again, and then we call it Butterschmalz.

You take it to cook, and it's a special fat. This fat, if you put it into special bottles with colors about green or black, there is no sun, and if you take it cold, you can keep it on business for about five to six years, no problem. In the history, it was very special and very interesting to get the fat in your business.

Without this fat, we call it in German Magermilch. With this Magermilch, they make this special cheese, the Surekäs. It's very easy.

They heat it up to 28 degrees, and then they put some special sour starter bacteria inside, and it's very easy. They make it by themselves with sourdough bread and Brunnenkresse. Then you got the sour bacteria into the milk, and after about 14 to 18 hours, the milk is broken, and you got the cheese.

Then you have to heat it once again up to 40 degrees, and afterwards, the cheese is already ready. You can put it out. In Austria, they take about 2.5-kilogram forms for this cheese, and they press it a little bit, and after 10 days, you can eat him.

You can also take this cheese, you can handle him for about eight months, nine months, or about 12 months. And it's very interesting. He changed the quality and the smell very, very extremely.

You got in the first a sour, fresh cheese, and afterwards, after you can say about five months, this cheese got a very strong skin, and the skin smells absolutely, yeah, we would say just for professional cheese eaters, not for the soft one, for the professional. And also inside this cheese, the smell keeps the first step of his living, and he's also fresh and sour, yeah. And I suppose there's a whole world, just like wine, cheese has a whole world of professional tasting, competition, and all that sort of thing, and I suppose some of your cheese has been in

competition in the past as well.

Yes, sure. Very interesting is about cheese. The stronger the cheese smell, the better taste is something with a sweet touch.

It can be shots. You can take wine. You can take fruits.

You can take juice. It doesn't matter. You can say, is there really a strong cheese? The much more you can drink something sweet about it.

It's very fantastic. Maybe you try. If you've got the chance, you take a very strong cheese, and you try it with a prosecco.

Yeah, it's a fantastic combination. Now, if we want to find you online, we can go to [www.caseyhaus](http://www.caseyhaus.at), that's K-A-E-S-E-H-A-U-S, dash montefond dot A-T for Austria. And where can people find you if they're coming to Austria here? You've got a fabulous, beautiful facility here.

Yeah. We are in the middle of Montefond. There is the biggest village.

It's called Schrunz and Tschakunz, and we are in the middle of both, on the highway to the Silvetta, Hochalpenstraße. Maybe if they visit us, also Silvetta Hochalpenstraße, Bieler Höhe. It's a very fantastic place, and it's a place you have to be once in your life.

That's great. And thank you very much for being with us. Werner Fritz, the owner here at the Case House Montefond, which is the Cheese House Montefond in Schrunz, and it's been a pleasure to have you on the program this week.

For me also, and the best wishes to Australia. Often the Austrians are – they mean the Australians are the Austrians, and the Austrians are the Australians. I think we are brothers, and yeah, I like it.

Thank you. Thank you very much, Werner. Great, great.

Thanks.